Alias Grace

By Margaret Atwood

GRACE: **(Pg 309-310)** Nancy said we was both to leave after the next day, and she had the money to pay us. She said that Mr. Kinnear was in agreement with her.

DR. JORDAN: Did you believe that?

GRACE: As regards McDermott, I did. But not as regards myself.

DR. JORDAN: Not yourself?

GRACE: She was afraid that Mr. Kinnear would come to like me better than her. She was in the family way, and it often happens like that with a man; *(voice gradually grows more coarse; rate of speaking slows – as if another persona has taken over Grace's speaking voice)* and they'll change from a woman in that condition to one who is not, and it's the same with cows and horses; and if that happened, she'd be out on the road, her and her bastard. *(voice shifts back to Grace's gentle cadence)* It was plain she wanted me out of the way. I don't believe Mr. Kinnear knew a thing about it.

DR. JORDAN: What did you do then, Grace?

GRACE: I cried, Sir. In the kitchen. It was at this time that McDermott said he had a secret, and I promised not to tell. Once having promised such a thing, I was bound by it. *(whispering and shocked)* He said he was going to kill Nancy with the axe, and strangle her as well, and shoot Mr. Kinnear when he came back and take the valuables; *(back to normal tone)* and I was to help him.

DR. JORDAN: You did not warn anyone?

GRACE: Please don't make fun of me, [Dr. Jordan], it is very distressing, and doubly so considering what I am being asked to remember. . . . **(Pg 312)** And I did warn Nancy! While she was brushing out her hair, I said, McDermott wants to kill you.

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She laughed and said, I expect he does. I would not mind killing him, either. There is no love lost between us . . . Then I knew there was nothing I could do to save her.

INTRODUCTION

The bodies were found in a cellar. Thomas Kinnear, the owner of the home, had been shot in the left side of his chest. Nancy Montgomery, his housekeeper and mistress, was struck in the head with an axe and then strangled. It was the summer of 1842 and conspicuously absent in the wake of the murders were two domestic servants: 20-year old James McDermott and 16-year old Grace Marks. The pair appeared to have fled Kinnear's home wearing clothing belonging to the deceased. They are quickly caught and charged with the murders. Dr. Simon Jordan, an up-and-coming expert in the burgeoning field of mental illness, is hired. His mission? To find out what really happened on the day of the killings. Was Grace the evil instigator of the murder plot or was she an unfortunate and vaguely stupid girl who had fallen victim to an overwhelming male villain in James McDermott? Based on a true story . . . this is Alias Grace by Margaret Atwood

GRACE: **(Pg 312)** That night Mary Whitney appeared to me in a dream.

DR. JORDAN: **(pg 102)** Who is Mary Whitney?

GRACE: Mary Whitney, Sir?

DR. JORDAN: It is written underneath your portrait. At the front of your confession. Grace Marks, Alias Mary Whitney.

GRACE: Oh, yes. It is not a good likeness of me.

DR. JORDAN: And Mary Whitney?

GRACE: Oh, that was just the name I gave, Sir, at the tavern in Lewiston when James McDermott was running away with me. He said I should not give my own name, in case they came looking for us.

DR. JORDAN: And did you give any name that came into your head?

GRACE: Oh, no, Sir. Mary Whitney was once a particular friend of mine. **(Pg 148)** [She] helped in the laundry [at the home of my previous employer]. **(Pg 149)** I liked her at once. Next to me she was the youngest one there. **(Pg 150)** I was often

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astonished at the words that came out of her mouth, as many of them were quite coarse; it wasn't that I'd never heard such language before, but I was surprised to hear it from a girl, and one so young and pretty, and so neatly and cleanly dressed. **(Pg 177)** I did not know she was going to die . . . . *(long silence; Grace is lost in thought)*

DR. JORDAN: [You were telling me about your dream . . .]

GRACE: **(Pg 312-313)** That night Mary Whitney appeared. It was not the first time; she'd come before, but never to say anything. She was holding a glass tumbler in her hand, and inside it was a firefly, trapped and glowing with a cold and greenish fire. Her face was very pale, but she looked at me and smiled. Then up ahead I saw Nancy, on her knees, with her hair fallen over and blood running down into her eyes. Around her neck was a white cotton kerchief printed with blue flowers, and it was mine.

DR. JORDAN: **(Pg 314)** You dreamt this before the event? *(writing feverishly)*

GRACE: Yes, sir. And many times since. That was why they put me away.

DR. JORDAN: Away?

GRACE: *(looking down at her hands)* Into the Asylum, sir. Because of the bad dreams.

DR. JORDAN: *(gently)* Only the dreams?

GRACE: They said they were not dreams at all, sir. They said I was awake. But I do not wish to say any more about it. *(Dr. Jordan steps out of the scene)*

DR. JORDAN: *(to audience)* **(Pg 373)** Grace's amnesia seems genuine enough, or so I have come to believe, in the light of my previous clinical experience. On the other hand, although she can't seem to remember the murder, she has a minute recollection of the details surrounding it. **(Pg 377)** I must admit I've been baffled. What she says has the ring of truth; her manner is candid and sincere; and yet I can't shake the suspicion that, in some way I cannot put my finger on, she is lying to me. *(exits)*

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TRANSITION

Months pass as Grace is questioned by Dr. Jordan. She tells the same tale over and over, lacing her tale with dreams she recalls – dreams about the murdered victims. But a person can't be convicted based on their dreams . . . or can they? It was then Dr. Jordan developed a plan.

GRACE: **(Pg 381-382)** When Dr. Jordan comes back, I am to be hypnotized. Dr. DuPont is to do the hypnotizing, and others will watch and listen. [They] said I need not be afraid, as I will be among friends who mean well, and all I will have to do is go to sleep when Dr. DuPont tells me to. When I am asleep they will ask me questions. In this way they hope to bring back my memory. *(Grace steps into scene, rigidly, her lips pressed together, she is obviously afraid)*

DR. JORDAN: **(Pg 397)** *(Grace pantomimes Dr. Jordan's description)* Du Pont turns the lamp down low and begins his procedure. First he suggests heaviness, drowsiness; then he tells Grace that her limbs are floating, drifting, that she is sinking down, down, down, as if through water. His voice has a soothing monotony. Grace's eyelids droop, she is breathing deeply and evenly. He asks: "Are you asleep, Grace?"

GRACE: Yes.

DR. JORDAN: "Good," he says. "Let us proceed." *(to Dr. DuPont)* **(Pg 399-404)** Ask her whether she ever had relations with James McDermott.

GRACE: *(laughs in a tone that doesn't sound like her own)* Relations, Doctor? What do you mean? Really, Doctor, you are such a hypocrite! You want to know if I kissed him, if I slept with him, if I was his paramour! Is that it?

DR. JORDAN: *(shaken)* Yes. *(to audience)* I was expecting a series of mere yes's and no's dragged out of her. Not such crude mockery. This voice cannot be Grace's; yet in that case, whose voice is it?

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GRACE: So I'll tell you. Yes. I would meet him outside, in the yard, in my nightdress, in the moonlight. I'd press up against him, I'd let him kiss me, and touch me as well, all over, Doctor, the same places you'd like to touch me, because I can always tell, I know what you're thinking when you sit with me. But that was all, Doctor. That was all I'd let him do. I had him on a string, and Mr. Kinnear as well. I had the two of them dancing to my tune!

DR. JORDAN: *(a horse creak)* Why?

GRACE: I would breathe like this. *(uttering a high moan)* I would twist and twine. After that, he'd say he'd do anything. *(laughing)* But why? Or, Doctor, you are such a curious man! Curiosity killed the cat, you know.

DR. JORDAN: Ask her if she was in the cellar of Mr. Kinnear's house on Saturday, July 23rd, 1843.

GRACE: Yes, I was in the cellar.

DR. JORDAN: Ask her if she saw Nancy there.

GRACE: Oh, yes, I saw her. As I can see you, Doctor, from behind the veil. And I can hear you too.

DR. JORDAN: Was she alive? Was she still alive, when you saw her?

GRACE: *(sniggering)* She was partly alive. Or partly dead. She needed *(a high twittering)* to be put out of her misery.

DR. JORDAN: Did you help to strangle her?

GRACE: It was my kerchief that strangled her. *(giggling)* Such a pretty pattern it had on it! It was a shame to lose that kerchief; I'd had it such a long time. It was my mother's. I should have taken it off Nancy's neck. But James wouldn't let me have it, nor her gold earrings neither. There was blood on it, but that would have washed out. . . . The kerchief killed her. Hands held it. She had to die. The wages of sin is death. And this time the gentleman died as well, for once. Share and share alike! *(Gleeful)*

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MRS. QUENNELL: Oh, Grace. I thought better of you! You have deceived us!

GRACE: Stop talking rubbish. You've deceived yourselves! I am not Grace! Grace knew nothing about it! *(Grace begins to hum/sing)* Rock of ages, cleft for me, Let me hide myself in thee! Let the water, and the blood . . *(see link at the end of this selection for song)*

DR. JORDAN: You are not Grace . . . If you are not Grace, who are you?

GRACE: *(continues singing)* Cleft for me . . Let me hide myself, in thee . . .

DR. DUPONT: You must answer. I command it!

GRACE: *(whispering)* You can't command. You must guess!

MRS. QUENNELL: I know you are a spirit. They can speak through others, in the trance. This one is speaking through Grace. But sometimes they lie, you know.

GRACE: I am not lying! I am beyond lying!

MRS. QUENNELL: It may be James McDermott, come here to sully Grace's reputation. To accuse her.

GRACE: Not James, you old fraud!

MRS. QUENNELL: Nancy, then. They are often rude. They call us names. Some are angry – those earthbound spirits who cannot tolerate being dead.

GRACE: Not Nancy, you stupid fool! Nancy can't say anything, she can't say a word, not with her neck like that. Come, Doctor . . . You like riddles. You know the answer. I told you it was my kerchief, the one I left to Grace, when I, when I . . . *(begins singing again: The Rose of Tralee – See link at the end of this selection for a link to the song)* Oh, no, 'twas the truth in her eye ever dawning, That made me love Mary . . . .

DR. JORDAN: Not Mary. Not Mary Whitey

GRACE: *(no longer teasing)* I told James to do it. I urged him to. I was there all along! But Grace doesn't know, she's never known! They almost hanged her, but that

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would have been wrong. She knew nothing! I only borrowed her clothing for a time.

DR. JORDAN: Her clothing?

GRACE: Her earthly shell. Her fleshly garment. But I wouldn't want to hurt her. *(pleading)* You mustn't tell her!

DR. JORDAN: Why not?

GRACE: You know why, Dr. Jordan. Do you want to see her back in the Asylum? I liked it there at first, I could talk out loud there. I could laugh. I could tell what happened. But no one listened to me. *(a small, thin sob)* I was not heard.

DR. JORDAN: Grace, stop playing tricks!

GRACE: *(hesitantly)* I am not . . . I am not . . . Grace.

DR. JORDAN: Is that really you? Are you telling the truth? Don't be afraid.

GRACE: You see? *(wailing)* You're the same, you won't listen to me, you don't believe me, you want it your own way, you won't hear . . . *(trailing off into silence)*

DR. DUPONT: Grace . . . Grace Marks, can you hear me?

GRACE: *(in her normal voice)* Yes.

DR. DUPONT: I am going to bring you up now. You are floating up, up. You will not recall what happened here. When I snap my fingers, you will awake. *(Snaps fingers)*

GRACE: *(stirring and opening her eyes, she smiles like a dutiful child)* I must have been asleep.

DR. DUPONT: *(gently)* You may feel a little dizzy. It is frequently the case. Mrs. Quennell, would you see that she is placed in a bed chamber where she may lie down. *(Grace exits)*

REV. VERRINGER: **(Pg 405)** Two hundred years ago, [we] would not have been at a loss. It would have been a clear case of possession. Mary Whitney would have been found to have been inhabiting the body of Grace Marks, and thus to be

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responsible for inciting the crime, and for helping to strangle Nancy Montgomery. An exorcism would have been in order.

TRANSITION

But medicine had made many advancements by the mid 1800's and no exorcism was performed. Grace's death sentence was commuted to life in the Asylum and in the mind of the public, justice was done.

GRACE: **(Pg 5)** It's 1851. I'll be twenty-four years old next birthday. I've been shut up in here since the age of sixteen. I am a model prisoner and give no trouble. If I am good enough and quiet enough, perhaps after all they will let me go; but it's not easy being quiet and good, it's like hanging on to the edge of a bridge when you've already fallen over; you don't seem to be moving, just dangling there, and yet it is taking all your strength.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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Rock of Ages hymn: *https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gM7gt_cSxjw*

The Rose of Tralee (Irish folk song): *https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Xo2Q74VN7IU*